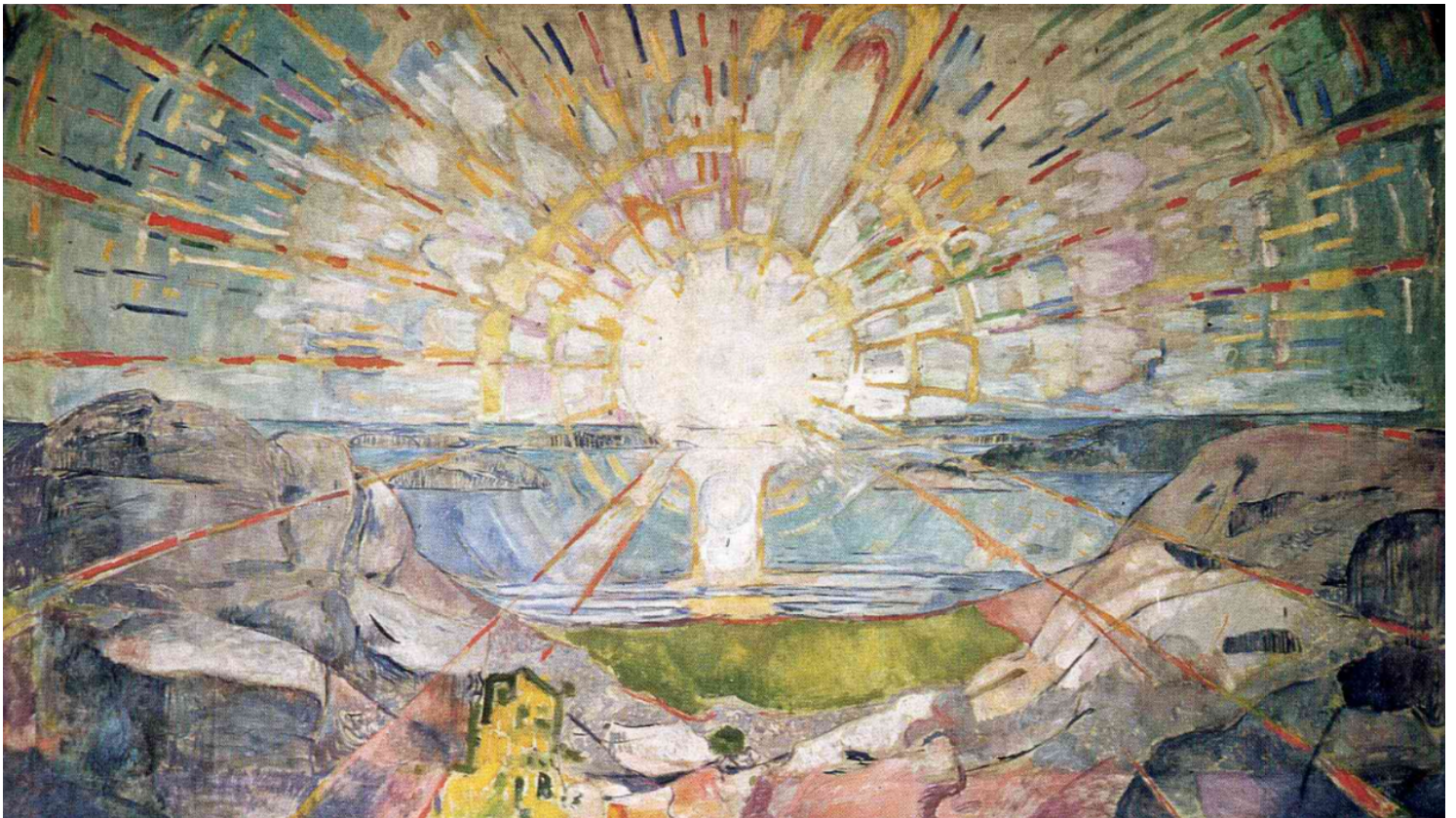


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Easter Sunday

*The Only Thing More Powerful Than Hate is Love
Put Your Hands on the Future*

5 April 2026



The Sun, 1911 by Edvard Munch

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Easter Hymn Improvisation

Pièce en Forme de Habanera for Trumpet and Organ (Maurice Ravel)

Organ Interlude: VICTIMAE PASCHALI LAUDES

Tonada De Luna Llena for Trumpet and Organ (Venezuelan Folk Song)

Organ Interlude: DIADEMATA

Concerto in Bb for Trumpet and Organ (Tomasso Albinoni)
- Allegro - Andante - Allegro

Gaudy Sanchez, Trumpet, Christoph Bull, Organ

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Easter Processional

***Easter Processional**

Christ the Lord is Risen Today

EASTER HYMN

Christ the Lord is risen today, Alleluia!
Mortal tongues and angels say: Alleluia!
Raise your joys and triumphs high, Alleluia!
Sing, glad heavens, and earth reply: Alleluia!

Let the Victor's people sing, Alleluia!
Where, O death, is now thy sting? Alleluia!
Dying once, Christ lives to save, Alleluia!
Where your victory, O grave? Alleluia!

Love's redeeming work is done, Alleluia!
Fought the fight, the battle won, Alleluia!
Death in vain forbids Christ rise, Alleluia!
God has opened paradise, Alleluia!

Soar we now where Christ has led, Alleluia!
Following our exalted Head, Alleluia!
Made like Christ, like Christ we rise, Alleluia!
Ours the cross, the grave, the skies, Alleluia!

***Easter Words of Gathering & Prayer of Awareness**

Brittany & Lance Skiles

Divine Creator of Easter promise and hope,
on this day, enter our lives with resurrection power;
grant to each of us gathered in this sacred place,
an exuberance for life,
and a desire to share the love of the Christ.

On this Easter day, we pray that many of the things
we are prone to disbelieve -
will be raised up as possibilities...
Led by the power of the Risen One, may we be empowered:
to exist in harmony and balance with the natural world,
to share the good earth in peace as children of humanity.

To work together for the building of your dream for us all,
to care passionately for those who need your love and our care,
and to live our lives filled with gratitude
on this day, and every day,
with hearts overflowing with grace and joy.

*Let our love this morning burst forth like laughter,
and our gratitude on this day of new life grow within us
as we share this time of celebration!*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

“Kommt Eilet” from *Easter Oratorio*
Cathedral Choir

J.S. BACH

***The Lord's Prayer**

Brittany Skiles

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.*

John Philip Newell

Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Easter Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

Life rises in our midst:
sometimes hard-won life.

It surprises us when it blossoms forth at unexpected times:
and in unexpected places.

It comes with power stronger than death:
life born of faithfulness,
life born of courage,
life born of God.

On this Easter Sunday,
may the peace of God found in this sacred place
be with you now, and in all the days to come!
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Easter Children's Conversation

Claire Kelly

Following this Conversation, children are invited to our Easter Festival and Egg Hunt at 12:30pm. If you were unable to check your children in prior to the service, please accompany them to our registration table and register them after this conversation. Then, after the service, follow the signs according to your child's age group and join them at their age-designated area for their Egg Hunt. Immediately following, we are all invited to the Easter Celebration in the Forecourt where you will find the Egg Hunt prize table, and Easter Treats for all ages!

The Reading from the Gospel *from the Gospel of Matthew, Chapter 28*

Lance & Brittany Skiles

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One, gathered here on this Easter morning,
we feel our hearts stretching toward new beginnings.
On this day we remember our hopes and our dreams,
we reflect on who we are and the ways our hearts
need to change in order to affirm our deepest aspirations.

In the holy stillness of this place we have come, O God,
seeking peace and the quiet serenity born of insight,
seeking beauty in the inner sanctuary of the sounds and sights of our lives,
seeking courage, and the fortitude to live our own lives.

Surrounded by the love given and received in this sacred place,
we long to be open to this incredible life that calls us forward
from old ways of being into new ways of embracing this new life,
offered to each and everyone one of us.

Help us to know and feel, O God, the embrace of this time,
as we are reminded once again that in this place,
we are loved - and we belong.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Reflection

Put Your Hands on the Future

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Musical Gift

“Bach and the Mexican Baroque” Part 2

“Alleluia and Veni Sancte Spiritus” ANONYMOUS SANTA CLARA MISSION
Laude

“¡O Suma Alegría!” MANUEL DE SUMAYA
Cathedral Choir, Katelyn Dietz, Lorenzo Zapata, Sharon Chohi Kim, and Frank Hobbs, *Quartet*,
Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Director*

“Jesu, Joy of Our Desiring” J.S. BACH
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

Orchestra: Maya Masaoka (*violin*), Diana Daw (*violin*), Nico Valencia (*viola*),
Greg Adamson (*cello*), Gabriel Golden (*bass*), Gaudy Sanchez (*trumpet*)

*We offer deep gratitude to the 100+ people whose financial contributions have made this morning
and the special music this year possible. If you would like to join them with a gift to music,
please leave a note designating “music” on your gift.*

Translations

“Kommt Eilet”

“Hasten, come quickly with great expectation to see the place where our Savior was laid and is no more.”

“Alleluia and Veni Sancte Spiritus”

*“Come, Holy Spirit, send down those beams that sweetly flow in silent streams from heaven above.
Come, Holy Creator and Redeemer of all who suffer, come and fill our hearts with love. Alleluia!”*

“¡O Suma Alegría!”

“O great happiness! O immense jubilation! The lights, the drums, the peals of bells tell us with tongues and voices of fire “Everything is Glory and Peace, Everything is renewal!” No, not only from a God, not only from the Word, but he, through the incarnation has become blessed. For his beloved healing comes into being from the people, the plants, and the flowers that animate him. O great happiness! O immense jubilation! Everything is glory and peace!”

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Communion Musical Gift

“Eternal Source Of Light Divine”

G.F. HANDEL

Laurel Irene, Soloist, Gaudy Sanchez, Trumpet, Christoph Bull, Organ

Invitation to Generosity

Lance Skiles

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

“Dona Nobis Pacem” from Mass in B Minor
Cathedral Choir

J.S. BACH

“Grant us peace.”

***Easter Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Brittany Skiles

Spirit of Liberation and Life, determined and gracious,
through these gifts, teach us of loyalty to love's ways.

May we become more committed to each other's flourishing.
May we be released from fears that cause us to hoard resources, power, and control.

May we become convinced of the power you have given us to disrupt, resist, and transform our world through loving intention, commitment, and peace.

May it be so, O God.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

We raced headlong into this morning
searching for life's newness,
remembering a promise that has called to us
over and over again.

We have greeted this day with gladness and rejoicing.
For we are people of hope.
We are people of new life.
We are people of vision.

And together we build this new world.
A resurrection of whole-i-ness
by which all the best of what we are
can breathe again,
and we can know the power of life.

As those born into this light and love ~
yet ever seeking it,
we say...

Amen and Amen!

Choral Response

"Hallelujah Chorus"
Cathedral Choir, David Conley, *Conductor*

G.F. HANDEL

***Easter Hymn for the Journey** *Celebrate a New Day Dawning*

HYMN TO JOY

Celebrate a new day dawning,
sunrise of a golden morn;
Christ our Savior dwells among us,
glorious visions now are born.
Equal partners 'round the table,
we make dreams reality;
Calling out our gifts we nurture
hope beyond all we can see.

Christ our Savior lights the pathway
to a world of harmony;
all our siblings' love surrounds us,
nourishing our synergy.
Earth joins in our rich communion,
grateful for our healing care;

Leaping deer and soaring eagles,
all Earth's fullness now can share.

Sing a song of jubilation,
dance with joyous revelry;
Clapping trees and laughing rivers
join our call to liberty.
Freed at last to blossom fully,
flowering forth in beauty bright,
We become a new creation,
bursting open into light.

- lyrics adapted from Jann Aldredge-Clanton

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Toccata in F Major from *Symphony No. 5* (Charles-Marie Widor)

Inside The Music

Dr. David Harris

"This year we're celebrating Bach and the Mexican Baroque for both Palm Sunday and Easter. We begin Easter with the opening choral movement of Bach's "Easter Oratorio." Though one of his less performed cantatas, it is rich with joyful celebration. You can hear the women running from the tomb, almost tripping over one another, to tell the others of the joy they discovered. Bach's triple meter dances and flows while his melodies chase one another around as timpani and trumpets cut through the air. We'll also sing Bach's iconic "Jesu, Joy" today. Thanks to its presence in weddings, it has become one of the most well known Baroque pieces in history. Though from a different cantata, Bach uses the same triple pulse to explore joy as a theme. In "Jesu, Joy" the triple pulse falls inside a broader meter. Unlike the running/tripping triple of "Kommt, Eilet," it is a more internal, deep joy that glows to all around. It is rarely heard with the trumpet part that he wrote as an obligato. This one, simple line somehow holds place for that glowing radiation of joy. On Palm Sunday we sang the "Sanctus" sequence from Bach's "Mass in B Minor." This week we'll sing the final movement from that work, his setting of "Dona Nobis Pacem." It is perhaps the most expansive, heart opening expression of those "Grant us peace" words that I know. Bach's rising fugue line builds energy on each repetition. It is an energy that has completion in its return to the note from which it began. That completion contains vast potential energy that releases joyfully into the countersubject that occurs on the 5th scale degree. The countersubject itself is also complete, returning each time to the note from which it began. In these complete statements we hear in Bach's music a kind of peace that looks inward. It trusts that peace can be found no matter the circumstance surrounding us. As we celebrate the meaning that Bach's music has allowed us to find over the centuries, we also seek to uncover newness in the less-heard voices of Mexico's Baroque composers. Manuel de Sumaya, indigenous to Mexico, became one of the most renowned composers of the Baroque era. His music is lively, broad, and layered. His output has been compared to that of Handel and Bach. He led music at the main cathedral in Mexico City in addition to writing secular works for the stage and instrumental pieces. His "O Suma Alegría" is a villancico. This song form was incredibly common in the Americas during Sumaya's life. They are typically written for Christmas, yet, many of them, like "O Suma Alegría" have a universal reflection. It also shows that the rhythms of the Americas are different, and the stories are told with an ear toward the earth and community that would have surprised Europeans of the time. The ideas of "everything is renewal" and "beloved healing comes into being from the people, the plants, and the flowers" simply didn't exist in European churches. They are distinctly indigenous philosophies that sing into the Easter story as we celebrate it at The Cathedral. We celebrate other music from the Mexican composers in what is now California with "Alleluia and Veni Sancte Spiritus," a piece of unknown authorship from the Santa Clara Mission. The tunefulness and rhythmic drive reveals the role of music in Mexico at the time. Music was a reflection of community

and celebration led by the people. As but one gleeful example, there is a note in the score under the chant section that “all will remain kneeling for the whole time that the drum is making a ruckus like organ pipes.” I can only imagine what a London, Paris, or Milan church would have thought about such a musical experience. We end Holy Week as we always do, with Handel’s “Hallelujah Chorus” to remind us that joy is ever with us.”

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